

Architects Collaborative closes doors after 50 years

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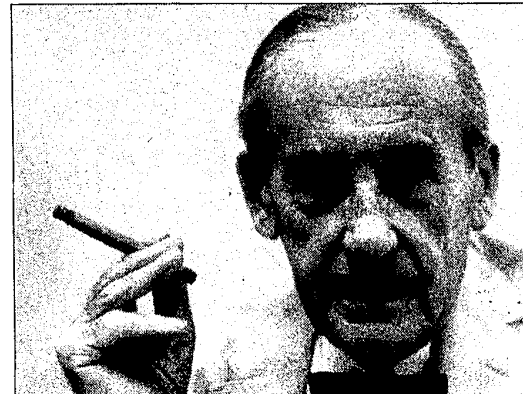
The Cambridge-based Architects Collaborative produced the Heritage on the Garden on Boylston Street, which reveals the firm's later contextual approach to design.



PHOTO / STEVE ROSENTHAL

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Bauhaus founder Walter Gropius, a TAC partner.

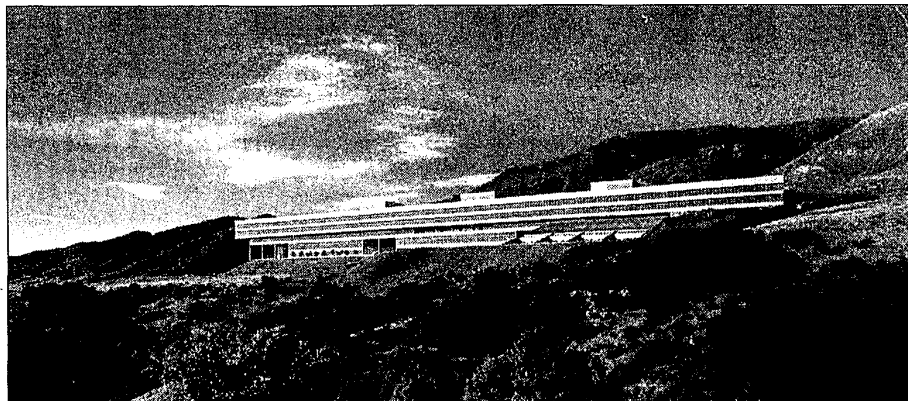


PHOTO / NICK WHEELER

The Johns Manville world headquarters in Colorado, produced during TAC's modernist phase. Eventually, the company's anonymity may have come to seem bland.

For Boston architects, it's as if the Titanic has gone down.

During most of its 50 years, The Architects Collaborative (TAC) was one of the top firms in the United States. At its peak, the firm was 400 strong, working in a building it designed and built for itself at 46 Brattle St. in Cambridge. But last month, TAC died. Unable to meet payments on debts to BayBank and Harvard University, it formally defaulted on April 7. A bankruptcy petition is anticipated.

How could this have happened? TAC's partners are surprisingly candid, although they're not eager to be identified by name. They say the firm got hurt by the Gulf War, when major projects in both Kuwait and Iraq went belly up and fees went unpaid. TAC bet heavily on the Middle East and was damaged earlier by the Iran-Iraq War. After the stock market crash of 1987, US developers, too, failed to honor debts. At that time the firm sold its building to Harvard to stay afloat, leasing back space. It was the Harvard lease on which TAC finally and fatally defaulted.

"We didn't cut back fast enough," says one key member of the firm. "We grew too fast and had a hell of a time trying to condense. We'd generated so much talent, it was hard to let them go."

At the end, TAC still numbered 55. "Everybody worked their heads off to save it," says a former colleague.

In its heyday, TAC was a legend. One of its seven original partners was Walter Gropius, founder of the Bauhaus school in Germany and later chairman of the department of architecture at Harvard. Because of Gropius, TAC was internationally prominent almost from the day it opened in 1945.

The other six partners were Americans still in their 20s, and included two married couples. They were youngsters who had met in school or while working for other architects, and who began to kick around the idea of starting a new kind of firm. It would be one in which nobody would be a star. It would be a collaborative. Everybody would work together on everything, criticizing and supporting one another. There'd be no Gary Coopers.

"We wanted to reform the world," remembers one founder. When they asked Gropius to join them, the old socialist was delighted. Half a century later, two of the original seven, Norman Fletcher and Chip Harkness, both now in

their late 70s, were still active TAC partners.

Over the years TAC became a sort of godparent to Boston architecture. Numerous other firms were started by architects who'd learned the ropes at TAC. In the 1960s, the American Institute of Architects established an annual national firm award. TAC won in the second year. Eventually, two of its Cambridge offspring would win that same prestigious prize. "We had so many graduates," says one partner. "We were like a graduate school, and we all remained friends."

What TAC didn't do was high-style architecture. Few of its works are particularly memorable as individual buildings. TAC really believed in the collaborative ideal, and was always more interested in solving problems than creating images. Among its best works, in fact, is one of its most modest: the community of modern houses the founders and friends built for themselves at Six Moon Hill in Lexington — another kind of collaborative where more than 90 children once frolicked.

Another early success was Harkness Commons and Graduate Center at Harvard, one of the first modern groups in the United States. Later came Baghdad University and other international work, many American college buildings, Copley Place, the Quincy School, much of Children's Hospital and a great deal else in Boston, as well as the Johns Manville world headquarters in Colorado. Still later, TAC successfully negotiated a transition from modernism to a more contextual approach, as in the superb Heritage complex across from the Public Garden. And there were many larger efforts: a prize-winning campus plan for Stanford University, resort towns in the Mediterranean and the vast Intermodal Transportation Center now finally nearing completion at South Station (co-designed with engineers HTNB).

TAC, especially in its beginnings, was an act of idealism. You'd think that if ever a firm deserved to survive its founders and prosper into future generations, it was this one, based as it was on the principle of collective accomplishment and personal anonymity. But perhaps that very anonymity came to seem bland, in an age of big-name architects and signature buildings.

What happens now? There's talk that some former TAC partners may form a small successor firm, maybe two — "if we can afford the insurance" — says one partner wryly. But nothing's definite. For the moment, there's only a huge void, now in possession of the bankers, at 46 Brattle St.

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